

Distinction between participial adjective and passive construction

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Participial Adjective: I was tired. Passive Construction: The window was broken by the ball.

Feature	Participial Adjective	Passive Construction
Grammatical Role*	Predicate adjective	Passive verb phrase
Main Verb Type*	Linking verb (be)	Passive auxiliary be + V3
Describes*	State or condition	Action done to the subject
Agent possible?*	No (usually)	Yes (often with by -phrase)
Replacement with seem / feel	Yes (I felt tired)	No unless poetic

Diagnostic Tests

1. Substitution with “seem” or “feel”

- **I was tired** → **I felt tired**
- **I was broken by grief** → **I felt broken by grief** (awkward unless metaphorical)

2. Agent Phrase Test

- **I was tired by the long walk** (ungrammatical)
- **I was broken by the fall** (passive with agent)

3. Question Form Test

- **Why were you tired?** → asks about a state

- **Why were you broken?** → asks about an event or cause

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Philosophical or Literary Use

Sometimes, the line blurs—especially in poetic or metaphorical language:

- **I was broken by grief** might feel stative, but grammatically it's passive.
- **I was exhausted** is clearly adjectival, even though **exhausted** is a participle.